PROMISE & PRACTICE · LEWIS & CLARK

The Journey That Began in Illinois

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

To the young United States it was a story of discovery — a dash across a continent to the Pacific. To the dozens of Native nations already living there, the same expedition was the first scout of something far heavier. One journey. Two ways to remember it — and it set out from the Illinois shore.

A continent already full

Before a single boat pushed off, the land Lewis and Clark were sent to "discover" was already home to hundreds of nations, each with its own territory, language, and history — as this early map tries to show. The West was unknown only to the men in Washington.

Map of the Indian Tribes of North America, about 1600–1800 A.D. — hand-colored map, public domain (Library of Congress).

Jefferson's gamble

In 1803 the United States bought an enormous territory from France — the Louisiana Purchase — and doubled in size overnight. Almost no one in Washington knew what was in it.

President Thomas Jefferson wanted to know what he had bought — its rivers, its wealth, and whether a water route, the fabled Northwest Passage, ran through it to the Pacific. He assembled an army unit, the Corps of Discovery, to go and find out.

"Louisiana," 1805 — engraved map of the new territory, public domain (Library of Congress).

What they thought was out there

These were the best maps of the West that existed in 1803 — full of blank spaces, guesses, and the word conjectural. Mapmakers hoped a short portage might link the Missouri to a river running west. There was no such easy route, but no one yet knew it.

Arrowsmith, "New Discoveries in the Interior Parts of North America" — public domain (Library of Congress).

It started here

Before the Corps went anywhere, it spent a hard winter in Illinois. On the east bank of the Mississippi, across from the mouth of the Missouri, the men built Camp River Dubois — Camp Wood River — and stayed from December 1803 into the spring, training and gathering supplies.

On the 14th of May, 1804, they pushed off from the Illinois side and started up the Missouri. The great western adventure actually began on our stretch of river — a detail the national story almost always leaves out.

"The Journey Begins Here" — interpretive marker at the Camp River Dubois site, Hartford, Illinois. Photograph, Wikimedia Commons.

Preparing the Corps

Through that winter the Corps built and loaded a 55-foot keelboat and two smaller boats, packing tons of flour, powder, tools, scientific instruments, and gifts for the nations ahead. Nearby St. Louis, a small French-speaking river town, was the last outpost before the unknown.

Everything the expedition would need for a year and a half had to be guessed at in advance and crammed aboard.

Inside a full-size keelboat reconstruction — the kind of boat that carried the Corps and its supplies up the Missouri. Photograph, museum exhibit (source to confirm).

Who actually went

Two captains led the Corps. Meriwether Lewis was the naturalist, trained by Jefferson to collect and describe; William Clark was the mapmaker and the steadier hand with the men. Around forty soldiers and boatmen went with them.

Two members did some of the hardest work and got almost none of the credit. York was a Black man enslaved by Clark; he hunted, scouted, and hauled for the whole journey — and at the Pacific was even allowed to vote on where to camp, yet was not freed for years afterward. A Newfoundland dog named Seaman made the whole trip too.

Meriwether Lewis — ink silhouette, public domain (Library of Congress).

Sacagawea and York

If the Corps had a secret weapon, it was Sacagawea. A Shoshone woman still in her teens, she made the entire journey carrying her newborn son on her back. She interpreted between the Corps and the nations they met, recognized the country as they neared her homeland, and — by bargaining with her own people for horses — made the crossing of the Rocky Mountains possible. The simple sight of a woman with a baby also signaled to every nation they met that this was not a war party.

York was the only Black member of the Corps, enslaved by Clark since boyhood. He hunted, scouted, hauled, and nursed the sick across the whole continent. At the Pacific he was allowed to vote on where the Corps would spend the winter — a voice no enslaved man had anywhere in the United States. When the journey ended, so did that equality: Clark refused to free him for years afterward.

Sacagawea guiding the expedition — a later artist's depictionbefore posting).

The tools they carried

The Corps traveled as a floating laboratory. With a sextant, a compass, and tables like these, Clark fixed their position again and again so the route could be mapped. The air rifle — a gun that fired on compressed air, with no smoke or bang — was demonstrated at councils as a wonder.

A sextant, used with the stars and sun to fix latitude and longitude — photograph, museum collection (source to confirm).

Orders, secrets, and speeches

Jefferson gave Lewis pages of detailed written instructions — map the rivers, record every nation and its language, catalog the plants and animals — and even a secret cipher for coded letters, in case the news was too important to send in the open.

The nations spoke back. Documents like this record Native leaders answering the government in their own words — a reminder that this was a meeting of two sides, not a march through empty country.

Jefferson's cipher for the expedition's secret messages — the practice line reads "I am at the head of the Missouri." Manuscript, public domain (Library of Congress).

Among the Mandan

The Corps spent its first winter beside the Mandan and Hidatsa, whose earth-lodge towns on the upper Missouri held more people than most American cities of the day. The Mandan fed them, traded with them, and kept them alive through brutal cold.

It was here they met a Shoshone woman named Sacagawea, who would interpret, calm tense meetings, and — by securing horses from her own people — make the crossing of the mountains possible. No portrait of her was ever made from life.

A reconstruction of Fort Mandan, the Corps' winter fort of 1804–05 — photograph, Wikimedia Commons.

Councils, speeches, and medals

At nearly every nation, the captains held a council: a speech announcing a new "great father" in Washington, a request for peace and trade, and the gift of a peace medal stamped with Jefferson's face.

To the captains these were gifts of friendship. But the speeches also carried a claim of sovereignty — that these nations now answered to the United States, over land they had never surrendered. The medal was a present and a flag planted at the same time.

"Captains Lewis & Clark holding a Council with the Indians" — woodcut, public domain (Library of Congress).

Dances and ceremonies

The journals describe dances and ceremonies at many of the nations the Corps visited — some to welcome visitors, some to call the buffalo, some to mark war and honor. The men watched, sometimes understood little, and wrote down what they saw.

Both the film above and this print were made by outsiders, years apart, for audiences far away. Neither is a neutral window. Part of thinking like a historian is asking who made an image of another people, when, and why — before trusting what it seems to show.

"Buffalo Dance," Edison Manufacturing Co., 1894 — film preserved by the Library of Congress (public domain). Read this carefully: this is an 1894 studio re-creation performed for Edison's camera — not footage from the expedition. Film did not exist in 1804. It stands in for the kind of dance the Corps described seeing among the Plains nations, and it is itself a source worth questioning.

Things made by hand

The nations the Corps met were not "simple." They were skilled makers — of clothing, containers, tools, and sacred objects, each shaped by deep knowledge of the land. Here are some of the kinds of things the expedition saw, traded for, and sometimes carried home.

A quill-decorated hide shirt — photograph, museum collection (source to confirm).

Food, trade, and belief

Trade kettles and pipe tomahawks show two worlds already mixing long before the Corps arrived — European metal reshaped into Native forms, passed hand to hand across a continent.

A stone mortar and pestle for grinding corn and seeds — photograph, museum collection (source to confirm).

The peoples of the Northwest

In November 1805 the Corps reached the Pacific and wintered in a soaking rain at Fort Clatsop on the Oregon coast. The peoples of the Northwest — the Chinook, the Clatsop, and the nations of Nootka Sound pictured here — were seasoned traders who had dealt with ships for years, and drove hard bargains with the hungry, ragged expedition.

"Lewis and Clark on the Lower Columbia" by Charles M. Russell, 1905 — watercolor, public domain. York paddles at left and Sacagawea rides amidships.

Mountains, rivers, and plains

Between the Mandan towns and the ocean lay the hardest barrier of all: the Rocky Mountains and the Continental Divide, where rivers stop flowing east and begin flowing west. The Corps crossed half-starved, on horses bought from Sacagawea's people, through country that looked nothing like the easy portage the old maps had promised.

All along the way they passed the camps and villages of the Plains nations — the people who made this one of the most heavily traveled, well-known landscapes on earth, to those who lived there.

"Distant View of the Rocky Mountains" — hand-colored aquatint, public domain (Library of Congress).

A continent catalogued

The Corps brought back descriptions of some 140 plants unknown to eastern science — pressed, sketched, and labeled with where each was found. The pressed specimens below come from later western expeditions, but show the same patient work of turning a living continent into a catalogue.

A sheet from the Lewis & Clark Herbarium — a plant pressed and carried home. Photograph, Academy of Natural Sciences / American Philosophical Society (verify permission).

New to science

Alongside the plants came roughly 120 animals new to eastern science — the grizzly bear, the prairie dog, the pronghorn, and birds like the one above. Jefferson wanted it all written down, measured, and when possible carried back alive or preserved.

Lewis's woodpecker — one of the animals the expedition described, and one that still carries Lewis's name. Photograph, museum specimen (source to confirm).

The maps that resulted

This was the single biggest result of the whole journey: Clark's map. For the first time the rivers and mountains of the West were set down with real accuracy — the blank spaces and the word conjectural replaced with fact.

Within a generation, maps like Burr's turned Clark's track into roads, territories, and borders. A good map is never just knowledge — it is a tool for taking possession.

"A Map of Lewis and Clark's Track Across the Western Portion of North America... 1804, 5 & 6" — public domain (Library of Congress).

Discovery — for whom?

The expedition mapped a route, named 300 new species, and strengthened the U.S. claim to the Northwest. It also opened a door — to the wagon trains, soldiers, and settlers who followed, and to the treaties, removals, and broken promises that cost the very nations who fed and guided the Corps almost everything.

The United States recorded this story in journals and maps. The nations recorded their own history too — in robes, in winter counts like this one, in memory. Same events. Two completely different records.

A Lakota winter count — a calendar that records one event per year in pictures. A Native way of writing history. Photograph, museum collection (source to confirm).

Why objects?

You have just seen this story told in dozens of pictures — portraits, maps, photographs of museum objects, even a film. Most of them were made later, by people deciding how they wanted the expedition remembered. They show you an opinion as much as a fact.

Four real things survive that let you check the story for yourself: the secret cipher, a peace medal, Clark's great map, and a Native winter count. Each was made and used at the time, for a reason. Question them carefully and they will tell you what people actually did — and whose version of events you are reading.